adding that, ‘No burial even remotely resembling this lavish Sumerian burial has turned up in excavations in the Indus area. Indus burials, which are relatively rare, contain the very simplest of ornaments, such as a shell bangle, no weapons and no hint of human sacrifice, whether of menservants or courtiers.’[31]

Based on all that we know today, it seems reasonable to say that the unique genius of the Harappans lies in building elaborately planned cities, and forging what seems a relatively egalitarian and non-warlike society. If only *this* could fire up our modern nationalists, I muse, rather than whether or not the Harappans created the Vedas or spoke proto-Sanskrit (more on this ahead).

The dining room in my hotel is also a round bhunga. At night it doubles up as a bedroom for the workers at the hotel. A set meal with papad, daal, a vegetable, ghee-coated chapattis, rice, salad, achaar and chhaachh comes for Rs 125, and a breakfast of upma or poha for Rs 70. The TV plays either IPL matches or Lok Sabha 2019 election news. The dining room is abuzz with flies. Little frogs hop in. ‘Many more come in the monsoons,’ says the only server in the restaurant. As a kid growing up in Gwalior, I saw frogs very often, but haven’t seen one in years in our cities—not the least because frogs are undergoing a massive die-off globally. The server, a chatty middle-aged villager, had earlier showed me wood and seashell fossils he had collected on his outings with geologists. He knows that India was once joined with South Africa, before it broke away a ‘long time ago’.

‘Bisht worked very hard,’ the server says in Hindi about Dholavira’s lead archaeologist. ‘Some people asked him, if the Aryans were not outsiders—as he held—why are there no horse bones here and at other sites? He never had a good answer. He half-heartedly cited the findings at Surkotada, though he knew that the “horse” reported there was really khur [Asiatic wild ass].’ The server shrugs, ‘I don’t know where that debate is now.’

That silly ‘debate’, I tell him, thanks to genetics, is now officially over; the Aryans indeed came from outside.[32] He nods and flashes a smile. Earlier in the day, one of the guides had also said that Bisht interpreted many findings in Dholavira through a Vedic lens.[33] ‘One shouldn’t bring *dharam* into scholarship,’ the guide had sagely said. ‘It doesn’t come to any good.’